



ZERO TOLERANCE: A signboard at a Barelvi masjid near Nagpur warns radicals

Wahhabi ideology," says Shabeeb Rizvi, a professor at Rizvi College in Mumbai who researches Islamic ideologies in India.

Even as Barelvi mosques struggle for funding, rows of shiny new Tablighi mosques funded by Saudi money have sprung up across the country from Haryana to Kerala and southern Gujarat to West Bengal. "Most Barelvi Sunni mosques are in a dilapidated condition so the hardliners donate money for repairs, appoint their own priest and slowly begin to take over," says Rizvi. About 30 per cent Barelvi mosques have been similarly taken over by front organisations of Wahhabi ideology over the past decade. But now, over the past few years, hundreds of Barelvi mosques have put up signboards warning the Tablighis, Deobandis, Jamaat-e-Islami, Ahle Hadis, their preachers as well as worshippers to keep out.

The Deoband Tablighi preachers, however,

deny that their ideology is spreading fanaticism amongst Muslim youth. Says Mohammed Patel, a Tablighi preacher: "How can an ideology or a seminary be held responsible for the violent behaviour of a few?" He compares the Tablighis to religious movements like the Swadhyaya Parivar or Gayatri Parivar. "What they are doing for Hindus we are doing for Muslims in order to bring them to the right path. What's wrong with it?"

The corollaries appear out of place if one were to have a look as to what they preach in their madrasas in Gujarat. Symbols of exclusive Islam are glorified and paragons of inclusive Islam, run down. Emperor Akbar is sold as an "untrue Muslim" and Aurangzeb an "ideal" Muslim ruler.

In Gujarat, clashes between the Deoband-Tablighi and the moderate Ahle-Sunnat Preachers of the Barelvi school have occurred in Bhavnagar, Junagadh, Surat, Dohad and many other places over the past decade. The Patel Muslims of south Gujarat's Bharuch were moderate until four decades ago when the Deoband-Tabligh preachers started swamping the area with their puritan message. Today most of the Patel Muslims are Wahhabis. The maulvis of Bharuch district are now carrying out the Wahhabisation of the Muslims of Bhavnagar. Mohammed Ali, a terrorist caught in 2001 from Sopore in Jammu and Kashmir told his interrogators that he had studied for four years at the Akwada Deoband-Tablighi madrasa near Bhavnagar.

In south India, key figures in the emerging climax are JIH and the Kerala Nadvathul Mujahideen (KNM) represented by two factions. The Jamaat-e-Islami was set up in Lahore in 1941 by Maulana Maududi, who gave a call for setting up Islamic states. The JIH is now experiencing a serious mood swing as it takes up fresh routes and stresses personal reforms and abandoning, at least privately, its earlier slogans of political Islam. Unlike other neo-fundamentalist groups with larger lukewarm flock, the JIH has fervent activists to its credit and preaches an anti-imperialist, anti-multinational line—rehabilitation of endosulfan victims in five panchayats in Kasaragod district, call for retraction the draft Coastal Zone Management (CZM) notification by the Ministry of Environment and Forests, "which would hand over Indian coasts to bigger players and multinationals", raising voice for people displaced for setting up the International Transshipment Terminal in Vallarpadam in Kochi and waging a campaign against the Pepsi plant in Kerala.

"These are posturings they use to make inroads into a secular society. They are yet to publicly question Maududi's idea of a religious state. In India they raise anti-fascist campaigns, but fail